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Ethical Conundrums in Software Development

The profession of Software Engineering carries many consequential decisions which effect not only the organization one works within but also the entire ecosystem in which they interact. A professional designs software that can have many unexpected consequences on all who utilize it.

Often in Software development employees are tasked with creating dark patterns within their applications. These dark patterns are designed to trap users within an application and extract as much as possible from them. This can be seen in social media where an infinite scroll traps all of a user's attention, or a multitude of notifications are sent in order to bring a user back into the app. Michael Beilfuss says, "Do not persuade people to do what is not in their best interest" (sec. 4.8). To develop these dark patterns will have tangible negative effects on the world around me. Within my professional career there will be moments where I must choose to continue developing harmful software, or attempt to mitigate harmful effects of my organization. I must navigate these complex situations in order to properly follow an ethical path.

Another scenario where I might be encouraged to violate ethical guidelines throughout my career in Software Engineering is in a situation where I am encouraged to copy another developer's code without attribution or consent. When confronting strict project deadlines, developers are frequently tempted to pull pre-existing solutions from public repositories or online forums like Stack Overflow without verifying software licenses or providing proper credit. However, incorporating external code without acknowledgment represents a serious breach of intellectual property and professional ethics. As Beilfuss states, "Without providing

accurate citation information, the practice of cutting and pasting... is nothing less than plagiarism (or theft); it is unethical, and may be illegal if it violates copyright law" (sec. 4.6). Relying on uncredited or unlicensed code can result in disciplinary termination for the individual engineer and expose the entire organization to costly copyright infringement lawsuits. In order to uphold personal integrity and legal accountability, software engineers must make the continuous effort to author original implementations or meticulously cite borrowed components.

Works Cited

Beilfuss, Michael. "Chapter 4: Ethics." *Technical and Professional Writing Genres: A Study in Theory and Practice*, edited by Eric Howerton, Oklahoma State University Libraries / Open Textbook Library, 2020, open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/721. Accessed 30 Sept. 2026.